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RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Title: Negotiating Resistance and Incorporation: Chinese Hip-hop as a Youth Subculture under Regulation and Commercialisation

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I. Introduction

The use of music as a medium of social comment and politics has been a long held practice, and hip-hop has been distinguished due to its strong links with youth identity and resistance to inequality. Hip-hop is a genre of African American and Latino marginalised people who became targets of discrimination and poverty (Chang, 2005, p. 34; Rose, 1994, p. 102). It has its origins in the Bronx, where it developed in the 1970s. It gradually evolved into a cultural phenomenon that transcended national boundaries and acquired new characteristics while maintaining all of its connection to community development, identity-construction, resistance (Alim, 2006; Pennycook, 2007, p. 45).

Hip-hop flourished in a very different political and media environment in China, influenced by the rapid commercialization of platforms and robust cultural governance and quick platform commercialization. Hip-hop was brought to the 1990s by transnational cultural flows and unofficial media circulation, gradually forming a youth subculture in big cities (Amar, 2018, p. 107). Rap gave the majority of young people a cultural language to describe everyday life, aspirations, stress, and social identification—issues that were typically incomprehensible in more traditional mainstream pop culture (Alim, 2006; Amar, 2018).

This led to a significant turning point in 2017 when the genre gained market acceptance and widespread exposure through rap competition programs, *The Rap of China* (中国有嘻哈). The show's success demonstrated how the platform economy has been able to market hip-hop as a commercial form of entertainment. National audiences are reached by underground aesthetics, which are given a commercial focus (Amar, 2018, p. 110; Luo and Ming, 2020, p. 7-8). Although this movement gave artists and producers new opportunities, it also raised the level of official authority's scrutiny and consideration of hip-hop's perceived social impact and cultural legitimacy.

In the mean time, the Chinese hip-hop scene has been shaped by state regulation and censorship in a way that directly affects what is made public. China's Ministry of Culture published a list of 120 songs in August 2015 that it claimed had violent, immoral, and obscene content (China Daily, 2015). The idea that popular music must adhere to acceptable social and

ideological standards was shaped by the scandal after scandal involving high-profile rappers enabled regulation further. Scholars have noted that this type of governance not only restricts distribution, it also encourages self-censorship and creative adaptation, leading artists to use indirect forms of expression or submit to safer content (Luo and Ming, 2020, p. 6).

Consequently, modern Chinese hip-hop exists in an evident contradiction: on the one hand, it is historically linked with subcultural protest and social commentary, and the rise and development of this culture in China are becoming more and more closely linked to mainstream platforms, market perspectives, and control limits (Luo and Ming, 2020). Artists can avoid punishment or elimination by using metaphor, symbolic plot, and coded language instead of being direct about criticism (Amar, 2018, p. 110). This raises an important question for media and cultural studies: given the widespread visibility and ease of management of a youth subculture, why would socio-political meaning not be reversed?

Even though the amount of information on Chinese hip-hop is growing, the literature that is currently available usually examines the aspects of regulation, lyrics, or commercialization separately. Less attention has been paid to hip-hop as a youth subculture, which is a cultural space where identity, authenticity, resistance, and incorporation are negotiated in the areas of style, language, performance, and audience interpretation. This paper fills such a gap by exploring the nature of how a socio-political message (especially identity, resistance, and empowerment) is conveyed and perceived by Chinese hip-hop under the dual forces of regulation and commercial integration. The study, which is based on the Subculture Theory (Hebdige, 1979), would try to explain how the introduction of underground culture into the mainstream does not erase subcultural meanings but rather reformulates them for a new context.

II. Problem Statement

The spread of hip-hop in China has very fast changed into a fairly underground youth subculture into a mainstream genre subject to commercialization, particularly following the blossoming of rap reality shows and platform-mediated distribution of music. Meanwhile, it exists in a highly controlled cultural setting, in which music is supposed to correspond to the professional acceptable values and social messages, which are supposed to be positive. This brings a contradiction to existence: historically the identity of hip-hop in the world is subcultural resistance and social commentary, but in China its survival and publicity frequently rely on conformity and self-censorship and commercial packaging.

The main point is that socio-political expression is not merely put to a halt by the regulatory pressure and market incorporation, but it is usually transformed by these forms. The public instances of the content removal and a stricter control (ex: the list of 120 songs being removed/blacklisted in 2015, most of these are rap tracks) proves that the line of what is permissible expression is enforced as a proactive tool, and this aspect leads artists and producers to resort to indirect means (metaphor, coded speech, displacing the narrative, softening the aesthetics, etc.) (China Daily, 2015). Nevertheless, although such dynamics are a common opinion topic, the scholarly understanding of how hip-hop has been, or continues to be, a youth subculture subject to commercialization and censorship pressures simultaneously, and what sorts of socio-political significations artists and audiences can still assert within such a restrictive influence, is still less than completely transparent.

The studies that are already carried out tend to focus either on (1) the textual/lyrical interpretation, (2) the policy and censorship systems, or (3) the commercialization and entertainment industry. Less developed is a collective interpretation of the sub cultural process: how identities, resistance and empowerment are generated, bargained and disputed within the cultural practices (lyrics, style, performance, platform talk, fan interpretation) as the genre is more and more assimilated into mainstream media and controlled cultural economies. That is, we still cannot really see clearly what resistance would look like when it is no longer capable of being uncovertly pursued, or how what is subculturally authentic is reconstructed when

popularity becomes the opportunity and threat it can no longer be.

Such gap is important as Chinese hip-hop is not only a genre of music but also a high-involvement space in the culture where youths meet and spread social discourses of class, urbanity, aspiration, inequality, identity and belonging. When market forces and regulation direct the genre to sanitized or politically safe expression, the social outcome is not just less political rap, but a shift in how the youth culture can even represent the social experience. In the absence of a more detailed explanation of these processes, we can hardly determine whether hip-hop in China is mostly turned into (a) an entertainment form consistent with the prevailing cultural norms or (b) a symbolic location servicing some form of minor negotiation or (c) a dichotomous realm where diverse scenes (mainstream vs underground) will generate various socio-political possibilities.

Thus, the main issue that the study will solve lies in the fact that the functioning of Chinese hip-hop as a youth sub-culture, which is subject to both state control and commercialisation at the same time, and the expression and interpretation of socio-political themes (identity, resistance, empowerment) within such conditions is poorly understood. It is with that gap in mind that this research delves into the study of investigating the cultural strategies employed by artists and interpretation work that is carried out by viewers with the view to the Subculture Theory being used as an essential parameter of explaining how the meaning of subcultures is re-constructed in circumstances of control and mainstreaming.

III. Research Objectives and Research Questions

1.1 Research Objectives

RO1: To determine and examine contemporary Chinese hip-hop culture in relation to socio-political themes, and, specifically, identity, resistance, and empowerment.

RO2: To discuss negotiations between the Chinese hip-hop artists and cultural producers and the state regulation and commercialization, such as the use of indirect or coded representations of sub-cultural authenticity in order to be seen in the mainstream sources.

RO3: To research into the ways in which audiences (particularly young listeners) comprehend and respond to socio-political messages in hip-hop when these take place in a controlled media setting, and variations in their interpretation between more mainstream and less mainstream oriented settings.

RO4: To contribute theoretically to understanding Chinese hip-hop as a youth subculture, clarifying how subcultural meaning is reshaped through processes of incorporation, constraint, and adaptation.

1.2 Research Questions

RQ1: How Chinese hip-hop and rap practices negotiate socio-political themes of identity, resistance and empowerment through a controlled cultural practice space?

RQ2: How do artists (e.g. metaphor, symbolism, indirect speech, etc.) choose to work around socially sensitive meanings in the face of censorship and commercial pressures, using cultural strategies?

RQ3: What do viewers mean by these socio-political meanings, and what are the differences in interpretation in audience segment, platform or mainstream exposure?

RQ4: How has commercialization and mainstream absorption transformed the subcultural identity of Chinese hip-hop particularly the conflict between the notion of authenticity and what can be represented as state/marketable images?

IV. Literature Review/Theoretical Framework

4.1 Hip-hop as a Global and Localised Cultural Form

Hip-hop has been a popular subject of research as a cultural phenomenon based on the experience of young people, social inequality, and symbolic resistance. Hip-hop began as a form of music and expressive reaction to structural marginalisation of the African American and Latino community in the Bronx of 1970s which was a combination of music, language, fashion and performance as instruments of building identity and commenting on the society (Chang, 2005; Rose, 1994). Early criticism has focused on the importance of hip-hop as a counter-cultural zone where disenfranchised youth create lived experience and refute dominant social discourses.

With the globalisation of hip-hop, scholars have paid more attention to the localisation processes of hip-hop. Hip-hop is not a rigid cultural item, but customizes to local social, political and cultural situational conditions and creates what is sometimes termed as being a localised product (Pennycook, 2007; Alim, 2006). Such cases as France, South Africa, Tunisia and Southeast Asia show how hip-hop often serves to enable youth to mediate issues of identity, inequality and power when a direct political outcry is restricted.

This literature sets hip-hop as a form of music, and as a cultural practice deeply rooted in youth subcultures, and therefore is somewhat pertinent to the analysis of the modern youth expression in non-Western and politically controlled conditions.

4.2 Hip-hop Development and Control of Hip-hop in China

Studies toward Chinese hip-hop reveal a unique development pattern existing due to globalisation, state regulation and the market forces. Hip-hop in China was introduced in the 1990s due to the transnational cultural flow, which involved the imported cassette tapes (dakou tapes), extraterritorial communities of Chinese, and later digitization (Amar, 2018; Tang, 2022). Emerging hip-hop in China was quite underground, with concentration in great urban centres and underperformance areas.

The mainstream explosion of hip-hop came in after 2017, specifically through reality

programmes broadcast on television and via platforms like The Rap of China. The available literature records how this mainstreaming process created the most visibility and a business opportunity, and at the same time created a more intense regulatory focus (Luo and Ming, 2020; Sullivan and Zhao, 2021). The fact that hip-hop is now under institutional control in terms of the Chinese media system can be evidenced by the fact that the 2015 decision to ban 120 songs online, followed by the introduction of the cultural norm of positive energy, clearly shows that hip-hop now falls within the contentious jurisdiction of the Chinese government.

According to scholars, these circumstances have influenced the performance of Chinese hip-hop. Artists tend to use metaphor, allegory, local dialects, and historical or cultural symbols as a tool to convey social meaning but to avoid censorship (Amar, 2018; Nie, 2021). Although this literature is very helpful to understand the regulation and lyrical strategy, a significant part pays attention to the mechanisms of regulations or the textual analysis, and thus, the overall subcultural process is not properly explored.

4.3 Research Gap: Regulation to Subcultural Negotiation

Although existing studies recognise censorship and commercialisation as defining features of Chinese hip-hop, fewer studies examine how hip-hop functions as a youth subculture under these conditions. In particular, there is limited research on how identity, resistance, and empowerment are negotiated not only by artists, but also through broader cultural practices, audience interpretation, and subcultural meaning-making.

Most current scholarship treats resistance as either present or absent, often measured through lyrical explicitness. This approach risks overlooking more subtle forms of symbolic resistance and cultural negotiation that operate within constrained environments. As a result, there remains a gap in understanding how subcultural meaning persists, transforms, or fragments when a youth culture is simultaneously regulated and commercially incorporated.

Addressing this gap requires a theoretical framework capable of explaining indirect resistance, symbolic expression, and the tension between authenticity and incorporation. Subculture Theory provides such a framework.

4.4 Subculture Theory as the Theoretical Foundation

This study proposal is based on the Subculture Theory, but the only fundamental theory basis used is Subculture: The Meaning of Style (Hebdige, 1979). Subculture Theory Theory represents youth culture as a mass organization, which creates alternative meaning in the style in which the mundane aspects of culture may have ironical meaning and become objects of value and identity among the insiders (Hebdige, 1979, pp. 23).

Notably, subcultural resistance does not necessarily bear the face of direct political resistance but rather the subcultural meaning is at all times under dispute, and the element of style, becomes a significant locus of attack where hegemonic meanings might be interrogated and re-configured (Hebdige, 1979, p. 3).

One of the major ideas in the Subculture Theory developed by Hebdige is incorporation (recuperation)- the way in which subcultural styles and meaning are repaired and dragged back into the mainstream through two mechanisms the commodity form (commercialisation) and the ideological form (institutional labelling and redefinition) (Hebdige, 1979, p. 94).

This idea is particularly pertinent when it comes to Chinese hip-hop, where subcultural authenticity is compromised through the platform-related commercial demands and institutional limitations that structure what kind of style and meaning may be circulated in the masses. In this work the Subculture Theory outlines the primary perspective through which socio-political discourse (identity, resistance, empowerment) can be interpreted and read when hip-hop becomes more noticeable and at the same time, more controllable, especially in terms of change of style, symbolic boundaries and incorporation (Hebdige, 1979, pp. 90 191, 94).

In order to provide theoretical stability, the concepts of Cultural Hegemony, Semiotics, and Speech Act Theory are not independent theoretical bases of this proposal. Rather, there are few and distinctively related contributions that are merely elaborations of support to perfect such application of the Subculture Theory in contemporary, media-impending scenes. Specifically, the idea of subcultural capital that Thornton (1995) has worked through and the issue of continually changing, movable quality of youth cultural groupings introduced by

Bennett (1999), facilitate the contextualisation of the production of authenticity, status, and belonging in late-modern cultural contexts. It is based on these contributions that this paper will bolster the use of Subculture Theory to Chinese hip-hop without altering the focus of the study off of the framework of Hebdige as the sole theoretical locator.

4.5 Applying Subculture Theory to Chinese Hip-hop

Subculture Theory can therefore be used to examine the Chinese hip-hop as a negotiated cultural space instead of an outright location of resistance or conformity in this research context. It enables the research to investigate:

- how hip-hop is a youth subculture that is put into regulatory restriction.
- how symbolic resistance is carried out in indirect or coded or aesthetic ways.
- how subcultural identity is transformed via commercialization and mainstream incorporation.
- how audiences are involved in making and oninterpreting subcultural meaning.

In place of the question, should Chinese hip-hop be considered political or not, in an overt sense, the current paper applies the Subculture Theory to identify how the meanings of socio-politics are redefined under the circumstances of control. Such a measure is in line with modern cultural studies thought capable of perceiving resistance as cross-contextual and symbolic, and uneven, particularly in non-liberal media systems.

Since this paper is based on Subculture Theory, it has a theoretical contribution to the arguments on youth culture, media regulation, and cultural adaptation, as well as it presents an empirically based examination of Chinese hip-hop as a shifting and conflicted subcultural movement.

V. Research Design and Methodology

5.1 Research Design

The research design embraced in this study is a qualitative research design to examine the role of Chinese hip-hop as a youth subculture in a state of control and commercialization. The qualitative method is suitable since the study involves the meanings, interpretations, and cultural practices as opposed to measurement and prediction. The research aims to learn how socio-political constructs like identity, resistance and empowerment can be expressed and put across throughout the hip-hop culture and how these meanings can be perceived by the artists and the audience.

The qualitative research is also very practical in the study of the subcultures because subcultural expression frequently functions using symbolic practices, narrative strategies and contextual meanings, which cannot be sufficiently portrayed with the help of quantitative methods. Based on the Subculture Theory, this research paper focuses on depth, context, and interpretation, in which a refined analysis of the cultural negotiation can be achieved as opposed to a causal generalisation.

5.2 Population and Sampling

Its research area is on individuals and cultural text with the recent Chinese hip-hop culture. The target population consists of:

- female hip-hop and rappers in China.
- experienced persons, related either to the industry (e.g., producer, dj, or organiser)
- young audiences and consumers that are active listeners and users of hip-hop music and online music websites.

Besides human subjects, the object of study is also the cultural texts, but in this case, the chosen hip-hop songs and online comments of the audience.

The sampling strategy will be purposive, and the participants will be identified based on the fact that they either have a relevant experience or understand Chinese hip-hop culture. This will make the participants rich in information and capable of offering valuable

information on the questions of the research. In suitable cases, snowball sampling shall be used in order to access more respondents via referral especially since it can be quite sensitive to talk about regulation and censorship.

5.3 Sample Size and Characteristics

The proposed study will incorporate about:

- 8-12 interview respondents such as artists, industry-related people and active listeners.
- 6-10 hip-hop tracks that were released around the year 2008-2025.
- Online audience comments were made based on the fan pages of the sampled songs involving the key music and video streaming websites in China.

The study will gather (approximately) 150 300 top-level comments (a top-level comment is defined as being the first comment on a song, unless there are reply threads, where in that case the corresponding-top-level comment was chosen) about each song, so a total of 9003, 000 comments will be gathered depending on the availability.

The proposed sample of the interview is deemed sufficient to perform a qualitative research since within this sample the thematic saturation is usually provided when the participants share the pertinent cultural experience. Multiplicity of perspectives in the hip-hop subculture is aimed to be observed by the diversity of the roles of the participants (artists, industry insiders, listeners).

The chosen songs will reflect relatively mainstream and somewhat non-mainstream settings, which allows comparing the various levels of visibility and control.

5.4 Data Collection Methods

Multiple qualitative sources of data will be used in this study to facilitate a form of triangulating and enhance the rigor of the analysis. Data will consist of primary data (semi-structured interviews) and secondary/public data (songs/lyrics and publicly available comments of the audience). The following methods will be used in data collection:

5.4.1 Semi-structured Interviews

The targeted participants who will participate in semi-structured interviews will be selected. To address the main issues, an interview guide will be designed that will cover the following aspects:

- individual involvement in hip-hop culture.
- perceptions of identity and authenticity.
- censorship and regulation experiences or observations.
- perceptions towards commercialization and mainstream visibility.

The semi-structured format gives flexibility of the participants to explain their experiences and also gives uniformity in the interviews. The interviews will be carried out online wherein secure communication platforms will be used and are likely to take between 30 and 60 minutes each. Interviews will be audio-recorded with the consent of participants and transcribed to be examined.

5.4.2 Song and Lyric Selection

A limited number of texts in the Chinese hip-hop songs will be chosen, which will be textually analyzed. Selection criteria include:

- appeals to socio-political themes (e.g., identity, social experience, resistance), or;
- evidence of censorship or alteration or controversy, or;
- meaning in the hip-hop communities (mainstream or underground)

The lyrics and publicly accessible information on the songs will be gathered through large Chinese music websites.

5.4.3 Briefing on Audience Comments

In the context of the audience discourse analysis, the current study dwells upon NetEase Cloud Music, Bilibili, and YouTube. Some of the most popular music related services in China include NetEase Cloud Music and Bilibili, which also have a highly active community of users who comment, debate over lyrics, a favorite artist, censorship, and genuineness. They are such platforms thereby offering dense information on how viewers perceive and bargain

by the socio-political implications of hip-hop in China under the repressive media climate.

YouTube is among the auxiliary platforms used to analyse the songs that were banned or censored on Chinese websites after the involvement of the ministry of culture. Since YouTube is accessible to the outside world and uploaded recordings are archived or uploaded again, it allows studying the viewers in relation to the prohibited or censored works that can no longer be found inside the country.

5.5 Data Analysis Techniques

Thematic analysis will be employed to analyse the data, as it is practiced by Braun and Clarke (2006). This approach is quite appropriate to determine the patterns of meaning of qualitative data sets.

The steps to be analysis will include:

1. Acclimatization to interview transcripts, lyrics and viewer comments.
2. Primary encoding to record the recurring themes and concepts.
3. One unites codes into generalized themes.
4. Revising and peering of themes concerning the research questions.
5. Analysis of the themes using Subculture Theory.

Besides this the theoretical interpretation guided by Subculture Theory will be used to analyze the conceptualization of symbolic resistance, authenticity and incorporation in the data. Cultural studies support ideas such as incorporation, subcultural style, symbolic negotiation, etc., will be used to facilitate the interpretation but will not lead to the inclusion of more core theories.

5.6 Ethical Considerations

The aspect of ethics is significant because cultural regulation and censorship in China is rather sensitive. The interviews will be purely voluntary, and the informed consent will be used on all the interviewees. The purpose of the study, the right of the participants to drop out of the research, and the use of the data will be explained to the participants.

To ensure safety of the participants, anonymity and confidentiality will be upheld.

Transcripts and reporting will be stripped of any identifying information and pseudonyms will be adopted. Any digital information will be stored safely and only the researcher would access it.

Through following the required codes of ethics in conducting qualitative social research, this study aims to guarantee honor of respondents at the same time complying with scholarly integrity and rigor of research.

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